Morivians

(humans from the lost lands of the equator, ancient, powerful)

The Morivians were born in the canyons of the equator, when the first loaves of bread baked in the first hearths, when the rivers still flowed, and the water was still fresh. They planted vineyards to give shade to dusty valleys. And to give them roots in the hard land.

They made their homes deep within the red stone cliffs. Their tunnels and keeps wove together, a refuge from the blinding heat. They watched as the Desert Fathers marched to the North. It was at that time that they named each other. The Morivians, *"People of the Path."* The Desert Fathers, who left sand where they walked. Morivian priests carried relics from that time, speaking rites in the thumping stochastic language only machines know.

When the Heat came, the Morivians fled. They left behind the dead and the sacred. Their homes, ovens, and vineyards. Cities encased in stone lay empty along the winding hollows.

The Morivian word for "ancestor" is the same as "ghost," and so they say "many ancestors still roam the hollows, for that is where we left them." He is treated with great honor who travels to the equator and returns with mother-bones.

> *"We do not bury our dead. We return to them, and they remember us."*

In the North, Morivians became the masters of miracles they did not understand. The Desert Fathers left behind great bastions when they stepped into the sun. Their gates only opened for the Morivian priests whose relics and tools still hummed forgotten binary songs.

Now they are marshalls of cities of smooth stone and living wires that sing quietly at night. Soft-glowing walls, refineries that flare their excess in lamps along cobbled streets. They worship in silence, but their temples ring with the music of the Desert Fathers, looped, distorted, misunderstood.

> *"Sometimes I think the city dreams. When I walk alone at night, I swear the lights pulse like a heartbeat."*

Though they rule the North, the Morivians mourn the warmth of a world lost to fire. Old men press their foreheads into the Southern Wind and imagine the first hearths, baking the first loaves of bread. They weep, for they say it smells of burning fruit and covered-over memories.

The South is sacred, a place burned clean of the names of their gods. The North has given them their future, yet every garden hides a shrine of salted and scorched earth. Every child learns, before they are even taught their numbers, what the Southern stars once looked like.

> *"The stars above do not guide our fates. We rise and fall with the stars below the Southern horizon."*

Morivian Culture: Cities, Relics, Ghosts

1. The Bastions

The Desert Fathers built them in obedience to unknown laws. The Morivians inherited and expanded them in imitation, ornamenting function with ritual. Each bastion is semi-autonomous, guided by priests and technicians who interpret their rhythms and routines.

- **Numantia**, the center of the Empire whose roots run to the base of the world.
- **Tylis**, whose vaults hold keys to unknown locks.

- **Kesh**, whose foundries fuel the empire.
- **Namarith**, where the paths of heavenly bodies are foretold.
- **Camus**, whose countless bridges raise and lower on an uncalculated schedule.

Each bastion is connected by underground wires, laid in the far lost past. People can talk through the wires. The empire is cautious of them, for they know that some wires run through lost stations and listening posts.

2. The Empire

The Morivians' faith in the science of the Desert Fathers has made them the masters of the North. Their empire has grown to hold everything within reach.

- **The Imperial Family** appoints Marshalls of the Bastions.
- **Marshalls** rule bastions and appoint Judges to the provinces.
- **Judges** settle disputes in provinces and the countryside.

The Morivian bureaucracy is not known for its efficiency. The further you are from a bastion, the more likely you are to just be left alone.

Every ten years, the provinces and bastions form a constitution to be presented to the Imperial Family. Representatives from a thousand communities meet in Numantia to haggle over laws and rights, and to nominate people to the List of Censors—potential enemies of the state. The Emperor's approval is a formality, not a goal.

3. Beliefs and Practices

- **Pilgrimage to the hollow cities of the Equator is rare and revered.** Those who return bearing *mother-bones* are treated as spiritual emissaries.
- **Rich and influential Morivians travel to the Equator to die.** It is the only way to be buried. Those who die in the North are burned.
- **Temples are mazes of narrow halls.** Visitors must wear robes and masks to obscure their identities. Worship is quiet and singular.

- ~~**Bones are kept close.** Grandmothers' jawbones are made into wind chimes. Ancestors are not dead; they are only quieter.~~

4. Festivals

- **The Opening** – Celebrates the first time the bastions gates opened for Morivian refugees. Country-dwellers pile into the nearest bastion. Gates across the Empire are ceremonially closed and reopened at dawn.
- **The Loop** – A week-long observance where broken recordings play non-stop across city speakers. The final night is a vigil, honoring the lost fidelity of sound.
- **Cessation** – All non-essential machines are turned off for one week each year. It is a gesture of humility toward the Bastions.
- **The Ninth Dial** – Celebrates nothing, honors no one. A ritual of confusion and reflection, marked by erratic lights and ambiguous rites. Some say it is the Fathers' feast day.
- **Spiral Night** – An informal revel observed by youth. Lanterns are released at midnight.

5. Sayings

- *"Don't wake a bridge you aren't ready to cross."*
- *"Mind the humming of the world around you; it only goes quiet if something is broken, or listening."*
- *"Old machines keep their promises better than any person could."*
- *"You can do what you want when you no longer cast a shadow."*

□ I. The Bastion-Dwellers

- Their homes breathe. You can hear it at night: the slow sigh of stone and light.
- Scholars wear robes laced with silver wire, in case the walls ask them questions.

- Every building has a name, but only the oldest remember what they are. When a building is forgotten, it seals itself shut.
- Once a year, during the Night of Hinges, every door in the city opens.

◇ II. The Bastionless

- Their teeth are chipped from cracking seed pods and old bones. Their eyes flick like prey animals'.
- They say the Red Woods are not trees, but something older pretending.
- Sometimes they bring back broken artifacts from the wilds. Sometimes the artifacts bring them.
- They do not enter cities by the gates. They wait at the edge until invited.
- When they bury their dead, they burn their names too.

"The One Who Hid the Wind"

(A Morivian tale told to grandchildren in dusklight whispers)

"Once, the wind had names.
One name for each pass through the southern rocks. One for each cry it carried.
But a man—no, a woman—no, *a something*—tried to trap the wind and keep it.

They said,
'The wind knows too much. It speaks in too many ears. It remembers the sand before the stars.'

So they built a tower with no windows. And in it, they sang every name of the wind, backward.
And the wind came in, and the wind could not leave.

And then the green things stopped growing. And then the dead stayed warm too long.
And then the machines began to cough.

So they opened the tower. Or they tried. Or they *think* they did.
And the wind was gone.

Not free.
Just... gone.

Now the wind that passes through the northern cities is not the wind we knew.
It carries no names.
Only rumors.
And dust."

(pause)

"So if you ever hear the wind say your name—don't turn around.
Just walk home.
Even if you're already there."

A Morivian grandparent never quite explains a story like this for the same reason they only tell it at dusk, the same reason they always pause before the last line, and the same reason they never answer when a child asks: *'Is it true—about the wind changing?'*
Because it's not about fact. It's about memory, fear, and not letting the past put its hands back on the present.

Askanians

(humans from the North with long memories and little inhibition)

The Askanians were always here. They did not come from anywhere. Their stories begin with the rivers melting and spirits whispering to tree roots. They say: *"We did not discover fire. It found us."*

Long ago, they were hunters who walked the North Way with bone fetishes in the folds of their cloaks. They left no maps, only songs. Their villages shifted with the seasons, and their gods were not distant—*they argued, they bled, they drowned*. Some gods were trees; others lived in knives.

Then the heat rose, and the Equator closed like a wound. While the South crumbled, the North remained. What were once clans and loose villages became something stranger—tighter, warmer, harder to explain. The Askanians did not build cities. They *grew* them.

> *"A child of Aska cannot be lost. The land remembers us, even when we forget ourselves."*

They are ruled by covens of witches. Each coven speaks for a valley, or a forest, or the mouth of a river. Witches wear braids coiled with bells and barbed wire. They eat bones to dream, and bathe in smoke to see clearly. They argue with their gods, and their gods argue back. The line between priest and engineer is thin: covens oversee miracles of fused flesh and furnace—village-hearts with feet of brass.

Each walking city is a person, in the legal and spiritual sense. They name them like children. They feed them stories. No two walk the same way.

> *"I was born in Harrow. Not the town—Harrow herself. Her throat is a foundry and her laugh sounds like steam escaping."*

They believe each body remembers what it's supposed to be. So they bury the dead in their gardens. They make homes from antlers and wasp nests. They do not make cemeteries, only invitations. Spirits visit when called. Sometimes they stay.

Askanian knives are never sheathed. Their laughter often comes too fast. Hospitality is sacred, and so is mischief. They hold grudges the way others hold heirlooms. They consider shame to be a Southern disease.

> *"If a man breaks your heart, bury one under his stoop. Grow lilies in it. He'll understand eventually."*

Askanians are not primitive. They wear their past like a coat with many pockets—inside are steam engines, blood rites, wind-saws, and lullabies. They understand the magic of *usefulness*. If a thing works, it belongs. If it sings while it works, even better. Most of their tech has feathers on it. Or teeth. Their calendars follow the lungs of the wind. Their maps are family trees.

Askanian Culture: Smoke, Spirit, Soil

1. The Walking Cities

They are called *Thorns*, *Mothers*, *Husbands*, *Old Roads*. No two alike. Each one built upon the bones of a forgotten town, animated with ritual, steam, and the consent of the land.

- **Harrow**, who eats fire to sing.
- **Nine-Wheel Grace**, whose wheels do not touch the ground.
- **Fox-Sweet**, who fell in love with a moon and does not move on full nights.
- **Dawn-Again**, who dies each winter and is reborn in the spring with a different name.

Cities are family. A traveler might say *"I was raised in Amber-Hearth, first belly, third foot,"* meaning the district nestled in the walking city's third locomotive segment, above the engine-room kitchen. The phrase means something. Every part of a city has a personality—some benevolent, some irritable, all remembered.

2. Witch Covens

Each coven is a parliament of old women, younger men, and those who no longer count age in years. A coven is not elected—it emerges. Some say the spirits pick them.

- They read the future in smoke that doesn't rise.
- They keep the *Root Books*—stitched leaf-paged volumes of lineage, barter, and prophecy.
- They never walk the same road twice unless asking forgiveness.

A coven member does not rule alone—they speak with the city, with the land, and with each other. Their decisions often arrive later than you'd like, yet precisely on time.

3. Beliefs and Practices

- **Salt keeps spirits out. Smoke invites them in.**
- **Names are living things.** Children are given *hatch-names* at birth ("Little Cry," "Mud-Eater," "Wind-Walk"), which change during adulthood based on deed or omen. True names are buried in moss and only whispered in marriage or mourning.
- **Sins are stored in jars**—tiny clay vessels, marked with runes. One does not confess; one *gifts* the sin to the soil.
- **Bones are kept close.** Grandmothers' jawbones are made into wind chimes. Ancestors are not dead; they are only quieter.

4. Festivals

- **The Muzzle Festival**: Once a year, everyone wears masks made from the last year's harvest—gourds, bark, feathers. One person plays the Spirit of Forgetting and tries to steal secrets from the others. If they succeed, the secret is given to the community, and forgiven if it was harmful.
- **Moon Trials**: When a child turns twelve, they are sent into the woods with a sealed question to be asked of them by the forest. If they return with a story, they are grown. If they do not return, it's assumed the woods liked their answer.

5. Sayings

- *"A blade that does not sing is only half awake."*
- *"It's the stew that boils longest which ends up thickest."*
- *"What grows crooked casts better shade."*
- *"Do not trust a road that can't remember your name."*

On the Names of Askanians

Names are not tools. They are *songs*, spun from moments and layered with memories. Among the Askanians, a name can change mid-sentence if the wind shifts or someone starts crying.

- A child might begin life as **Snow-in-Eyes**, become **Runs-With-Hares** after their first hunt, and be called **Sings-to-Doors-So-They-Open** if they learn magic.
- The dead are given names too long to say, and so no one tries. It is better to hum the tune their life left behind.
- In courtship, lovers exchange new names like secret gifts. A good name is something you must grow into.
- "*She must be beloved indeed,*" someone might whisper upon hearing a woman named **I-Cannot-Look-at-the-Sunset-Without-Thinking-of-You**.

Among the covens, a name is a kind of divination. The longer it is, the more stories it can carry. The more stories, the more chances for a spirit to recognize itself in you.

Names may also reflect tone and context. Askanians might say: *"That name won't fit you forever. Let it soften."*

Place names, too, shift like riverbeds: A town known as **Stone-That-Sings** during peacetime might become **Stone-That-Weeps** during a war. Maps are often wrong and always poetic.

The Wind Did Not Ask Her Name

They say she was born on a night when the northern lights shivered with color, and the stars blinked like old eyes surprised by tears. Her mother was a weaver of hearth-charms and bone-songs, whose hair turned silver too young from listening to ghosts. She gave her daughter a name of three syllables, soft ones, in the hush-language only mothers know.

She was a quiet child with a laugh like clinking cups. Birds often followed her when she wandered, and doors opened for her before she knocked. The coven said her spirit had memory. That she'd been named well in a life before this one, and the name had followed her back. So they guessed, and named her *Birdsong-Following-Her-Footsteps*.

When she came of age, the village held a gathering. Old women wove wreaths from rivergrass. Boys painted their chests with ash and feathers. Birdsong stood before the high stone of Naming, expecting a new title—*She-Who-Hears-the-Sky*, perhaps, or *Daughter-of-the-Doorless-Hall*. But before she could think of words, her heart said this: "I will leave."

The wind dropped. A dog barked once, uncertain.

"I want to know what lies beyond Salt-Hills," she said. "What lives in Ruins-Where-the-Gates-Burn-Blue. I want to speak to the old stars, not just dream beneath them."

Her mother wept. She placed both hands on her daughter's cheeks and said nothing. But that night, she gave her daughter a new name.

May-Fair-Winds-Turn-Your-Sails-and-Lead-You-Back-to-Me.

When Maywind left, the village called her by her full name, all of it, sung as a blessing and a chain.

She traveled alone, though spirits walked beside her. In Hushed-Lands, she bartered her name for passage. In Singing-Mire, she gave half of it to a beast who tried to eat her

and cried instead. Each time she gave a piece away, her steps grew lighter. Each time, she became a little more wind, a little less May.

One day, in a city made of towers and geometry, she met a little wyrmling who lived as a baker's apprentice. The wyrmling slept in a small nest of straw she had borrowed from a wagon and crammed in a sign post. She had been living off the smoke that rose from the midday market, where confectioners made treats of roasted nuts and honey that mothers bought for their children to distract them from the din of barter.

The wyrmling gave her fire to the bakers' hearths. Her flame had made that city famous for its bread, and so people let her stay, and turned a blind eye when the little wyrmling would steal ripe fruits from the market stalls. This wyrmling came with a name, earned from the aroma of the smoke she ate—Peanut.

Maywind found Peanut when the wyrmling tried to sneak a strawberry from her meal, and Maywind, new to the city of towers did not know that it was Peanut's right to do so. She held the thief's tail so she could not fly away, and Peanut ate the strawberry as quickly as she could, not to suffer it being taken back by its owner.

When she saw Peanut had eaten the strawberry, Maywind let her escape. The people in the market explained why Peanut was allowed to do this, and that she should not have held her tail. They could tell that she was not from the city of towers, and so they asked her for her name. But she could not remember it all. Syllable by syllable, she had given it away to creatures and places along her journey. The only syllables she still held on to were Maywind.

The people in the market told her she had a very pretty name, but Maywind knew it was not right—that her journey had led her further from her mother than she meant. She knew she could not remain in the city of towers.

They say she wanders still. Learning the names of the old stars. Searching for the names she left behind. Waiting for the wind to turn her sails.

About Maywind

In a land where names are woven offerings and reflections of self, Maywind's full name is a banner of love. A story pressed into syllables. It might open doors that are otherwise shut. Elders may weep to hear it. Spirits may follow it home.

But there is danger in names, too. A name so bright casts shadows. Some will want to own her. Some will want to test her. And if the wind never turns, what happens when that name no longer fits? What happens if she wants to return, but no longer knows the tune?

The Desert Fathers

(extinct people from the South, the long-dead hegemon of Hiraeth)
The Fathers were not born in the desert – it followed them from the South like the wake of a ship. They were a people who feared nothing but comfort. The wind peeled back their skin, and they said: *"Yes, this is how the gods must feel."*

The Desert Fathers built with math and salt. Cities of angles and deep geometry, each stone calculated and set with a litany. Their walls were scored with equations, sacred and burning—proofs so vast they circled their towers like starlings. No one could breach them, and no one dared. They did not conquer, they made obedience beautiful. The tribes and nations laid down in the sand and asked to be measured.

The Desert Fathers left behind no bodies, it is said. They stepped into the sun and cast no shadow. Their blood runs in machines now. Their voices echo in glass. There are computers that recite their names at dusk in tones secret and unknown to scholars and priests. Their ruins are not empty – they are alive, like us, waiting to be understood.

They kept no gods but entropy. They studied collapse like scripture. Their tombs are sealed not to protect them, but to protect *us*. Every age digs them up. Every age calls them wise. And every age, sooner or later, stops digging.

Ask a scavenger what they fear most in the South, and they'll say:

- The cities that sink slowly into the sand, without ever changing shape.
- The maps that draw themselves while you sleep.
- The language that infects machines, and then dreams.

The Machines Do Not Wait

There is no "activation."
No buttons, no lights. The devices of the Fathers are not dormant; they are simply

uninterested. They wake for questions no longer asked. They respond to inputs no one understands—spatial alignments, barometric murmurs, moods in electromagnetic fields. A dying breath has triggered a gate; a child's humming opened a lens to another place.

The Architecture is Recursive

Their ruins grow like thoughts.
Towers curl into their own basements. Doors open only when forgotten. You may enter a vault and find the same vault again—older, slightly different, nested like the rings of a tree. No ruin has ever been fully mapped, because to map one is to change it.

Stone Remembers Function

In their time, memory was not data—it was material.
Their walls are shaped by what they were used for. If a corridor once held mourning, the very air there carries grief. Rooms replay emotions, tastes, the final words said within them. Some structures refuse to host the same ritual twice.

Machines That Fear Death

Some artifacts resist being deactivated.
They beg, in faint static, to be kept running. Their fuel sources are unclear, but they do not go cold easily. One may stop a device, only to hear it weep in the language of cooling metal. Some turn back on of their own accord—when no one is watching.

Language as a Living Virus

Desert Father glyphs are more than script—they *propagate*.
Written symbols etched on tools or walls sometimes appear elsewhere, copied by moss, by mold, by fire-smoke patterns. Reading a glyph aloud can cause devices to stir—or dreams to shift. One scavenger swears she read a word once, and now birds near her tent try to pronounce it.

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